SEND WITH THE SCRIPT

# Self-recording guide

Reality-TV confessional style: you sit and talk to the camera, deadpan. No interviewer, so prop up your own phone, or let whoever sent you this hold it, and record it in five minutes whenever you have a free moment.

### Setup

- **Nobody films you.** Prop your phone horizontal against a stack of books or a mug, at face height, about an arm's length away. Sit in a chair against a plain wall or a bookshelf.
- **Light:** face a window or a lamp. Don't sit with a window behind you.
- **Eyeline:** look just to the side of the lens, as if a producer is sitting next to the phone. Glancing at the lens once or twice is fine.
- **Tone:** deadpan beats hammy. You are a sincere person who has nothing to hide and is slightly annoyed to be asked.

### Recording

- **The script:** read it from a second screen or a printout taped just under the phone. The *(beat)* and *(pause)* marks are where the laughs live. Hold them longer than feels natural.
- **Takes:** two max. Send the slightly flubbed one. Don't edit anything.
- **Length:** 60 to 90 seconds. Start recording, wait two seconds, begin. Stop two seconds after the last line.
- **Send it:** text or AirDrop the raw video to whoever sent you the script. They add the title card and load it onto the classroom laptop.

### Making the script yours

Words in [brackets] are adjustable. The facts the kids check (shoe size, where you were, what you wore, how you feel about squishies) live on your **Suspect Statement form**, not in this video. The box at the top of your script gives you the four answers to write on the form, the one or two things the video has to agree with, and the lines to keep word for word. Everything else is flavor. Swap in your real life, your real subject, your real habits. Wear whatever you like. True details get the biggest laughs.

## The ask (email or text to each suspect)

Subject: 5 minutes of acting for the 4th grade Halloween party?

Hi [Name],

Mrs. Driscoll's class Halloween party on Oct 30 is a whodunit, and the kids are going to investigate four staff "suspects." Would you be one of the three who record a statement? All it takes is a 90-second video of yourself that you can record alone on your phone whenever you have a free minute. No one films you, no one edits you, and you don't need to attend the party.

Attached are your script and a one-page Suspect Statement form. The top of the script gives you four answers to copy onto the form so the kids' clues line up; the rest of the form is yours, and true is funnier. The video is a monologue, so just talk to the camera. Quick tips:
• Phone horizontal, propped at face height, plain wall behind you
• Look just beside the lens, like a producer is sitting there
• Deadpan. Sincere. Slightly annoyed to be asked.
• Hold the pauses. Two takes max. Send me the raw video and the filled-in form by [Oct 23].

The kids will watch it on the projector during the party and, I promise, lose their minds. Thank you!

[Your name] · [room parent for Mrs. Driscoll's class] · [phone]

The Custodian gets a different ask: "You're a suspect who declined to comment. That's it. That's the whole job. Please act shifty in the hallway on Oct 30."

VIDEO 2 · PLAYS AFTER STATION 2

# VIDEO 2 — THE READING SPECIALIST

self-recorded monologue, ~75 sec · Zero information. Genuinely does not understand squishies and is a little offended to be asked.

TITLE CARD · INTERVIEW 2 · THE READING SPECIALIST · 11:05 AM

**MAKE IT YOURS (read before you record)**

- On your Suspect Statement form, write these four exactly (the kids check them against evidence): Q1 at 2:15: "The reading room. Where I always am." Q3 shoe size: 9. Q4 wearing: "Orange. It's a school color. Half the building wears orange." Q5 squishies: tick DON'T GET THEM, "You squeeze it. It goes back. That's it." Answer everything else however you like; true is funnier. Hand the form in with your video.
- On camera, two things have to agree with the form: you were in the reading room, in the building, at [2:15], and you genuinely don't get squishies. Nothing you wear matters, here or at the party.
- Linked to another clue: the [foam avocado] squishy. The mummy's witness statement and the Chief's confession both mention the avocado one. Change it only if the room parent changes those too.
- Free to change: [the reading room] (wherever you actually work), [sounding things out / blending things], [chapter book], [the good bookmarks]. Swap in your real reading life.
- Keep exactly: "I just don't understand the obsession these days." The kids will quote it.

**Words in [brackets] are yours to adjust. Say them naturally, without the brackets.**

*(Sit. A book in your lap, one finger holding your place. Look just beside the camera. You are missing a [reading group] for this.)*

I'm missing a [reading group] for this, so.

Where was I at [2:15] yesterday? The reading room. Where I always am. [Sounding things out. Blending things.] The cycle of life.

Did I go near Mrs. Driscoll's room? I go near every room. I pull kids out of every room. That's the job.

*(long sigh)*

Okay. Can I say something about these squishies? I don't see what these kids see in squishies anyway. You squeeze it. It goes back. You squeeze it again. It goes back again. That's it. That's the whole thing. No plot. No characters. I just don't understand the obsession these days.

***(beat)***

So no, I didn't take that jar. Why would I take a whole jar of something I don't understand? You want to steal something, steal a good [chapter book]. Those have endings.

***(pause)***

And before anyone asks: yes, I have a key to the book room. I have a key to every book room. Nobody's accusing me of stealing [the good bookmarks]. (look back up) Are you writing that down?

***(beat)***

Last thing. Whoever has those squishies: there's a whole class of kids out there who can finish a [chapter book] in a day but can't go an hour without squeezing a [foam avocado]. Think about that.

*(stand up)*

I'm going back to the reading room.

*(Walk out of frame. Stop recording.)*

SUSPECT STATEMENT

OFFICIAL

MRS. DRISCOLL'S DETECTIVE BUREAU · CASE #1031

# Suspect Statement

Answer every question. Print clearly. This will be read by detectives aged nine and ten. They notice everything.

**Name** _____ **Job at this school** _____

**1. Where were you yesterday at 2:15 PM?**

_____

_____

**2. Who can confirm that?**

_____

**3. Shoe size** (we will check) _____ **4. What were you wearing yesterday?** Color counts. _____

**5. Squishies. How do you feel about them?**

☐ Love them ☐ Don't get them ☐ What is a squishy?

_____

**6. Have you ever been inside Mrs. Driscoll's room?**

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Define "inside" _____

**7. Did you take the Jar?**

_____

**8. Anything else the detectives should know?**

_____

_____

_____

**Signature** _____ **Date** _____

**OFFICIAL USE ONLY**

Cleared by: ☐ Clue 1 footprint ☐ Clue 2 timeline ☐ Clue 3 orange sweater ☐ Clue 4 witness